

Pre-submission peer review report

Original research · clinical cohort study · two reviewers · 23 comments

This is a redacted sample. It shows the structure and level of detail of a real deliverable. Client names, journal names and identifying particulars have been removed or changed. Ask us and we will send one built around a manuscript like yours.

Summary verdict

Both reviewers judge the study sound and the analysis appropriate. Neither would recommend acceptance as submitted. The work required is real but bounded: two analyses to run, one claim to soften, and the reporting checklist to complete.

Grade	Count	What it means
Critical	3	Would cause rejection or major revision at the target journal if left.
Major	9	A reviewer would require this to be addressed before acceptance.
Minor	11	Improves the manuscript; unlikely to block it on its own.

The three critical comments

Critical 1 · Sample size not justified

No power calculation is presented and the sample size is not justified. A statistical reviewer will ask whether 248 was chosen or arrived at. Supply the pre-specified calculation with its parameters and cite the registered protocol, which establishes that it preceded recruitment.

Critical 2 · Causal language exceeds the design

The Abstract and the closing paragraph both state that the intervention “reduces” mortality. This is an observational cohort. The limitations section is correct but the two most-read sentences in the paper are not. Rewrite to association and add a residual-confounding sentence.

Critical 3 · Primary outcome not clearly pre-specified

The composite endpoint reported is not the one named in the registration. Either report the registered primary outcome as primary and this one as secondary, or explain the change and when it was made. Editors check registrations, and an unexplained switch is the single fastest route to rejection.

Reporting checklist

STROBE completed against the manuscript. Twelve items are fully reported, six partially, four not at all.

Item	Status	Note
6a · Eligibility criteria	Partial	Inclusion given; exclusion criteria are in the protocol only.
9 · Bias	Not reported	No statement on how potential sources of bias were addressed.

Item	Status	Note
10 · Study size	Not reported	See Critical 1.
12c · Missing data	Partial	Numbers given; the handling method is not stated.
16a · Adjusted estimates	Reported	Confounders listed and adjustment stated.

Free re-review. Revise and send it back. The same reviewers check whether each comment has been answered, at no further charge — which is also the closest thing to a rehearsal for what the journal will do.

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